

Prague Castle

The largest ancient castle in the world and a thousand-year-old seat of the Bohemian kings and later of the Czech State

Perched high above the Vltava River, Prague Castle was developed over several centuries, and its long and varied history is reflected in the mixture of architectural styles and variety of religious, royal, and military buildings found within the complex.

Changing times

The castle complex dates from the late 9th century, when Prince Bořivoj—the first Christian ruler of Bohemia—chose the site as the seat of his power, erecting a fortified wooden castle protected by a moat and ramparts. Churches dedicated to the Virgin Mary, and later St. Vitus and St. George, were among the earliest buildings erected at the site, although their original structures were subsequently destroyed or rebuilt. St. Vitus was replaced with a larger Romanesque church in the 11th century, when the castle became the seat of the Bishop of Prague. It was rebuilt

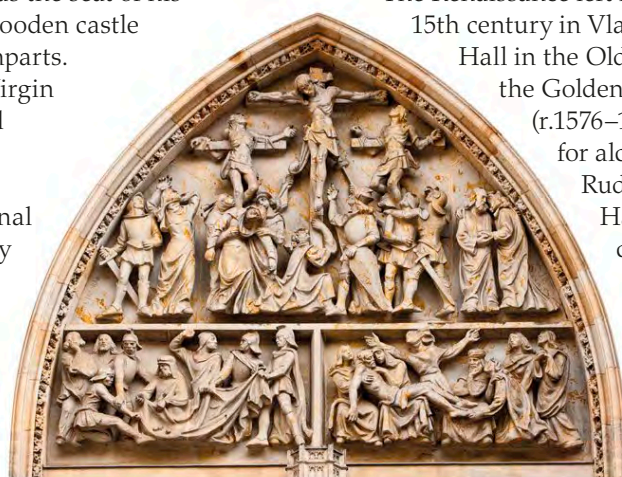
again as a grand Gothic cathedral in the reign of the Holy Roman Emperor Charles IV (1316–1378), at which time Prague was the seat of power of a vast empire that stretched from modern-day southern Denmark to northern Italy and from Belgium to Krakow in Poland. The wooden castle was replaced in the 12th century by the Romanesque Old Royal Palace, which was itself rebuilt under Charles IV, who covered some of its roofs with gold-plated metal sheets.

The Renaissance left its mark in the late 15th century in Vladislav II's (r.1471–1516)

Hall in the Old Royal Palace and in the Golden Lane that Rudolf II (r.1576–1612) built as a home

for alchemists and servants.

Rudolf also built the Spanish Hall to house his vast art collection, sadly looted in the Battle of Prague (1648).



◀ CATHEDRAL CARVING

This detail from the sculpted portal at the west end of St. Vitus Cathedral shows scenes from the life of Christ.

The Czech writer **Franz Kafka** lived on **Golden Lane** from 1916 to 1917



CASTLE PLAN

The Prague Castle complex covers an area of 750,000 square ft (70,000 square m). It is built around three courtyards, the largest of which is dominated by the Gothic St. Vitus Cathedral, whose 338-ft- (103-m-) high main tower is one of Prague's most recognizable landmarks. Today, the castle is home to the Czech president and the crown jewels.

